



Sir Clive Sinclair

Sinclair and Spicer keep mum over Taos and PCG-1

First copies of Sir Clive Sinclair's brainchild superchip, the PCG-1, should be in the hands of developers this month. With this super-fast Risc processor will be an operating system, and my bet

— based purely on hunch, I'm afraid — is that this will be Taos, the new 'atomic operating system' under development at Tao Systems. Sinclair himself was reasonably low key about the

chances of showing the chip to anybody. 'It would be a miracle if anything this complex worked first time,' he said in a very uncharacteristic imitation of Eeyore the Grey Donkey. He has some spare time to play with: Taos, if it is going to be the operating software, will not be ready until October at the earliest.

That said, Taos is very, very exciting indeed. It is a parallel operating system with a difference. Set against rival products like Helios from Perihelion, it promises to be considerably faster and much more flexible in the way it handles the job of sharing a program around multiple chips.

Making statements like that is an invitation to controversy, and the directors of Tao Systems (pronounced 'Dow' if you aren't into Eastern mysticism and didn't know) are happy to invite dispute.

The basis of Taos is that the data drives itself. Each processor in a network is a message-passing 'object' and programs are defined by which objects of code in the system as a whole are being used. 'It is very object oriented, but not the way people think,' said Nik Spicer, managing director of Tao Systems.

Each processor has an imitation computer written into it. This is a VP, a virtual processor: no matter what chip it is running on, the VP has 16 general purpose registers of 32 bits in size.

What makes the system remarkable, even if you haven't seen the demonstration, is the size of the code. The entire core of the operating system, including an assembler, linker and executor called Alex, should fit into 32k — one copy of that core runs in each processor.

The demonstration is worth getting to see. Chris Hinsley, who developed the core, originally developed the concepts when writing video games. His onslaught on the Atari ST is an amusing demonstration of the power of his method — it looks just too fast and too complex for a machine like the ST to move all those things around a screen.

This operating system, loaded onto the 750 million instructions per second engine that is the Sinclair PCG-1, would be a fearsome beast. The chip is designed expressly as an emulator chip and would be able to run IBM standard software easily. Couple that with Taos' ability to run multiple tasks on a single processor, or on multiple processors, and you'd have a very fierce machine.

Interestingly, I found Spicer quite relaxed in talking about this fact that he was going to show the Taos demonstration to Chuck Peddle, who is designing a parallel system in the US. This despite the fact that Peddle himself hasn't actually seen the software: his UK presence is Chris Badham, formerly with Tandon, and Badham has expressed considerable interest but no more had been done before this column went to press in early March.

What triggers my hunch is simply that I noticed, reading my notes after my interview with Spicer, that he was happy to answer questions about Peddle and yet somehow, without my realising it, he managed to change the subject every time I mentioned Sinclair or the PCG-1.

I rang Sir Clive and asked him what operating system he would be using. 'Not prepared to say, I'm afraid,' he said in said Eeyore tones.

Help still required in the new DesqView

As a way of running a dozen DOS programs on a single computer at the same time, DesqView, now around in version 2.26, is still supreme. Nobody has yet persuaded me to abandon my enthusiasm for it, and so I loaded the latest version together with the newest version of its memory manager, Gernu.

First the good news: it works much better than before, and it is much easier to squeeze the last ounce of RAM from your system with this version. In

particular I had fewer crashes, and those I did have were things I can recover from.

The bad news: you still do need access to help on occasion.

I remain romantically disappointed that the little guy (Quarterdeck) didn't defeat the big guy (Microsoft) by imposing DesqView on the market instead of Windows. In the end size and influence counts, and despite the many, many embarrassing failures of Windows in the market,

persistence seems to have established it at last.

DesqView is still little enough known that you have to say what it is every time you mention it. All DesqView does is allow owners of MS-DOS machines to run more than one program at a time. So, I can write an article with WordStar and edit a page with Ventura and search for a phone number in AsdSam or dBase and dial into a bulletin board or send electronic mail. And all these tasks are running

together, and I can watch whichever one I am interested in.

Theoretically, OS/2 does the same. And equally theoretically, Unix can compete with these two. At the moment all my software requires DOS, however, and what I want is a way of making it easier to use. The new version of DesqView 386 does this.

The main changes in the new release appear to be a program called Optimiser and another called Manifest. Manifest is great, but hardly manifest. One of its best features is a trick I saw Gary Saxer, technical director of